FREE GUIDE

German Citizenship Checklist

Everything you need to apply for Einbürgerung, step by step.
Made for expats living in Germany.



Updated October 2026

General information, not legal advice. Rules vary by state and by case.

1. Quick eligibility check

Tick every box you can answer with yes. If one is missing, the next pages show how to close the gap.

- ☐ I have lived in Germany **lawfully for at least 5 years**, and my stay is meant to be long term.
- ☐ I hold a **permanent right to stay** or a residence permit that qualifies. If unsure, ask your office.
- ☐ My **identity and nationality** are documented with a valid passport.
- ☐ I speak German at **B1 level** and can prove it with a certificate or a German school degree.
- ☐ I can pass the **naturalization test** (Einbürgerungstest) or hold a German school certificate that replaces it.
- ☐ I **support myself and my family** without Bürgergeld or similar benefits.
- ☐ My **record is clean**: no suspended prison sentence over 3 months and no fine above 90 daily rates. Offenses with racist, antisemitic or inhuman motives always count.
- ☐ I can sign the **commitment to the free democratic basic order** and to Germany's historical responsibility, including the protection of Jewish life.

What changed recently

June 2024: Germany allows multiple citizenships. On the German side you generally no longer have to give up your old citizenship.

30 October 2025: The 3-year fast track (C1 German plus special achievements) was abolished. The standard path is now **5 years** of residence for everyone.

Spouses of German citizens and a few other groups follow different rules. Ask your citizenship office about your case.

Source for the requirements: the German federal government's naturalization information (October 2025) and city citizenship offices. Details can differ slightly by state.

2. The process, step by step

Nine steps from first idea to your German passport. Most people spend the longest on steps 4 and 7.

1. **Do a quick pre-check**
   Many cities and states offer a free, non-binding online pre-check. Search your city name plus “Einbürgerung Vorprüfung”.

2. **Get your B1 German certificate**
   A finished integration course or a German school degree may already count as proof. If not, book a B1 exam early, slots can fill up.

3. **Pass the naturalization test**
   33 multiple choice questions, 17 correct answers to pass. The fee is 25 euro. All questions come from a public catalogue of about 300, and free practice tests exist. Book through a Volkshochschule or test center.

4. **Collect your documents**
   Use the checklist on the next page. Order certified copies and translations early. Foreign birth certificates can take weeks.

5. **Submit your application**
   Apply in person or online, depending on your local office. The fee is 255 euro per adult. Applicants aged 16 and over apply for themselves.

6. **The authority checks your file**
   Your office may involve the police, the domestic intelligence service (Verfassungsschutz), the social office and the employment agency. Answer any request quickly.

7. **Wait for the decision**
   Processing can take up to 18 months or longer, depending on the state and the office. A complete file is the best way to avoid delays.

8. **Ceremony and certificate**
   You sign the declaration and receive your Einbürgerungsurkunde. You become German from that moment, not before.

9. **Apply for your German ID and passport**
   Bring the certificate to your local Bürgeramt and apply for your ID card and passport.

3. Document checklist

Your office has the final say on what it needs. Use this as a starting point and compare it with your office's own list.

Identity and residence

- [ ] Valid passport or other photo ID
- [ ] Residence permit (Aufenthaltstitel)
- [ ] Registration certificate (Meldebescheinigung)
- [ ] Birth certificate, with translation or apostille if requested

Family and civil status

- [ ] Marriage certificate, if married
- [ ] Divorce decree, if divorced
- [ ] Children: birth certificates and proof of custody
- [ ] Written consent of the other parent, if only one parent applies for a minor

Language and knowledge

- [ ] B1 German certificate, integration course certificate or school degree
- [ ] Naturalization test certificate (Einbürgerungstest)

Income and insurance

- [ ] Employment contract and recent payslips
- [ ] Latest tax assessment (Steuerbescheid)
- [ ] Self-employed: profit and loss statements and tax filings
- [ ] Proof of health and long-term care insurance
- [ ] Proof of pension provision
- [ ] Rental contract or proof of housing costs

Other

- [ ] Completed application form
- [ ] Biometric photos, if requested
- [ ] Police clearance from other countries, if requested
- [ ] Anything else on your office's own checklist

4. What it costs

Item	Cost
Application fee, per adult	**255 euro**
Minor child naturalized with a parent	**51 euro each**
Naturalization test	**25 euro**
B1 German exam	Varies by provider
Certified copies, translations, apostilles	Varies
German ID card and passport after naturalization	Separate fees at your Bürgeramt

If paying is difficult, tell your office. A reduction or payment in instalments may be possible.

5. Tips for Americans in Germany

- **Dual citizenship:** Germany now allows it. The US generally does not require you to give up US citizenship when you become a citizen of another country. Confirm your own situation with the US embassy.
- **Passports:** US citizens must enter the US on a US passport. Keep both valid.
- **Taxes:** US citizens file US taxes wherever they live. Becoming German does not change that. A cross-border tax advisor is worth the money.
- **Benefits:** Bürgergeld or similar means-tested support can block your application. Unemployment insurance (ALG I) is usually treated differently. Ask your office before you decide.
- **Long stays abroad:** Residence must be continuous. Ask your office how it counts longer absences.
- **Apply as a family:** Minor children can be naturalized together with a parent, for 51 euro each.
- **Keep copies of everything** you hand in, and keep your application complete. Missing papers are the most common cause of delays.

Official sources and next steps

Always check the current rules with your own citizenship authority (Staatsangehörigkeitsbehörde or Einbürgerungsbehörde). Not sure who is responsible for you? Call 115, the German public service hotline.

Where to look

bamf.de: information on the naturalization test and practice questions

bundesregierung.de: federal overview of naturalization requirements

Your state or city portal: application forms, document lists, pre-check

115: public service hotline to find your office

Important

This guide is general information and not legal advice. Laws, fees and local practice change, and every case is different. Status of this guide: October 2026. If your situation is complicated (criminal record, long absences, self-employment, unclear residence status), talk to a specialist lawyer for immigration law (Fachanwalt für Migrationsrecht).

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